

Secondary directions

Enigma Factsheet · Secondary directions

Secondary directions are based on the analogy of a day — the rotation of the Sun — and a year — the revolution of the Sun. The changes in the sky during the first day of life are used for the first year of life, the second day for the second year, and so on.

Real days

You cannot compare calendar days and calendar years; these are human-constructed concepts. Due to daylight saving time and leap days, you would encounter illogical discrepancies.

Enigma works with the mean solar day. This is a constant factor that always applies. The differences with calendar days and years are limited but not insignificant.

Factors involved

Slow-moving planets will barely change position in secondary directions; we usually disregard these. The MC, Ascendant, and house cusps complete a full circle each year and therefore move approximately one degree per day — you will not use these in secondary directions either.

A hybrid variant

Some astrologers move the MC by one degree per year and calculate the Ascendant and sometimes the house cusps accordingly. This is seen as part of secondary directions, but that is incorrect. This movement of the MC is a primary direction, not a secondary one. When you combine both, you are working with a hybrid system.

Secondary directions or progressions

Secondary directions were introduced by Placidus. At that time, there were already directions in which the celestial vault was advanced by approximately one degree per day. To distinguish between them, Placidus called the older variant the primary directions and the variant he introduced the secondary directions.

In modern astrology, the term 'progressions' for secondary directions has become commonplace. In Enigma, I use the historically correct term: secondary directions.

Babylonian

John Timperman, an expert in Babylonian astrology, has found indications that secondary directions were already used by the Babylonians. This is not entirely certain, but it is clear that the principle of large and small cycles that can be compared with each other fits within Babylonian culture.



1. *Timperman, John* - Gids tot de Babylonische astrologie (Dutch). Deerlijk, België, 2025.
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